

GO GREEN

MACHU PICCHU

This city is built amidst clouds and nature. This extraordinary settlement lies halfway up the Andes Plateau, deep in the Amazon jungle and above the Urubamba River.

Through well thought-of planning, metropolitans could also be easily developed into 'garden cities' and help us do away with pollution and traffic woes here.

India is experiencing rapid infrastructural growth and urbanisation in cities is also burgeoning. The most common example of this urbanisation in metros includes the increasing extent, volume and number of multiplexes, mega malls, sky-rocketing buildings and towers in every corner of the city. Between all this, the only retreat is — greenery in metros. Nature's capability to restore to existence has been badly affected and it has led to exposure to greater physical and psychological health risks. Depriving ourselves of greenery could actually lead to an increase in stress, general anxiety and other mental health problems. Greenery in cities is important not only as it adds to the aesthetic value of urban forestry but also as parks and gardens in metros can make a significant contribution to the health and well-being of public and also help in improving the quality of life.

Careful and judicious planning and usage of natural resources — good soil, abundance of water-bodies, plenty of rainfalls, favourable climate etc. can convert our metros from concrete jungles to beautiful garden cities. Greenery reduces air temperature and also helps in protecting the roads and multi-storeyed buildings of metros against floods, landslides etc. Open spaces like parks and gardens are when perfectly blended with the planning of the city, forms a rare combination of nature and urban life. Unlike in British era, when there was an organised and planned channel of open spaces in cities and metros which had contributed majorly to the uninterrupted flow of traffic, today in India there are congested thoroughfares as we only think of horizontal expansion. Hence, the possible solution could be the introduction of open spaces into the crowded localities in adequate numbers and sizes.

Green spaces can be found in plenty in metros but their qualitative usage is where one should focus on. In order to increase the green belt and conserve bio-diversity in the metros, the focus should be on the development of theme parks like botanical gardens. Shooting down the excuse that there is no land for the development of parks and gardens in the metros, the possible solution could be that the rooftops can be converted into a green-patch using fertile soil and a low-density polyethylene sheet. Each building can have a world of its own if a proposition of recycling of resources and regeneration of wastes in its own premises will be followed. The mission is to enrich and regenerate greenery in cities and metros.



GROWING SATELLITES

PETRA, JORDAN

Petra, considered to be the most gorgeous ancient site in Jordan, was carved out of the rugged mountains in such a manner that it became a marvel for centuries to come.

Likewise, small towns and cities of India, which were till a decade back considered insignificant and not worth mentioning, are today catching the attention of one and all. With realty is in its full boom in these thriving small settlements that are well on their way to become major commercial and residential hubs of the nation.

Small towns and cities of India are making their presence felt. Be it Navi Mumbai or Manesar, they all have struck the right chord by giving thrust to sustained planning, infrastructure developmental projects and industrial growth. For instance, Rudrapur, a small city in Uttarakhand, is witnessing its rise as an industrial hub and a modern urban centre. A slew of measures like declaration of Rudrapur as a non-tariff area for central excise, custom and sales tax duties for a period of 10 years are good enough to entice big players to start their operations in the region. An investment of over Rs 30,000 crore is expected along with the generation of 44,000 jobs in this small city.

Even Manesar is fast coming out of the shadow Gurgaon's suburb. The IMT Manesar Industrial Area has played a significant role in transforming this small village into an industrial hub, sending the real estate prospects to unbelievable heights. The rates of commercial properties in Manesar have increased by 35 per cent to 60 per cent in the last few months. Residential properties are also not far behind; three bedroom houses are costing no less than Rs 1,800 per sq. ft. to Rs 2,200 per sq. ft.

When we are talking about the rise of the smaller cities, it is difficult not to mention Navi Mumbai, which is attracting industries big time. A host of developmental projects — International Infotech Park at Vashi, Technology Centre at Belapur, Millennium Business Park at Mhape and many more — are on the anvil to catapult it on to the world-map. Stupendous infrastructure worth Rs 40,000 crore is already in place and the government of Maharashtra is making special efforts to further add to it.

It should, therefore, not come as a surprise if these smaller towns and cities are touted as the future driving force of the Indian economy, when there is so much happening on the real estate front.

